

By Raj Chengappa

In 2012, the movie, the earth as we know it is destroyed because of a sudden burst of solar flares that heat the planet's core, causing major shifts in tectonic plates. The result is cataclysmic tsunamis, earthquakes and volcanoes that wipe out most of life except for a modern fleet of arks that the G8 countries have built to save a few. It's a gripping plot.

In 2015, and this is real life, R.K. Pachauri, the chairman of the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change (IPCC), based on scientific studies projects that if nations continue to emit Greenhouse Gases (GHG) at current levels, the average global temperature would exceed the tipping point and cause irreversible climate changes.

Already, much of the world is feeling the stress—the past decade has seen the hottest summers, the fiercest cyclones and typhoons, the worst droughts and downpours, alarming rise in sea levels and the collapse of agriculture in many countries. Nearer home, the drought that India faced this summer, Mumbai's crippling downpours and Cyclone Nargis, that lashed Myanmar, are seen more as disasters triggered by climate change. The threat is not just biophysical but social too with the number of failed states likely to go up, leading to the export of terror, drugs,

arms and immigrants, making the world more insecure and unsafe.

Yet judging from the response to the Climate Change summit currently underway at the Bella Centre in Copenhagen, the earth's reality show doesn't seem to inspire the 192 countries gathered to discuss the looming crisis, to stand up, and act with alacrity. At the start of the conference, Connie Hedegaard, the energetic president of the summit, tried to whip up some

FAILING TO DELIVER

The Copenhagen summit was to ensure that rich nations significantly reduced their emissions and provide finance and technology to poor nations

► EMISSION CUTS

WHAT THE RICH WERE TO DELIVER

Legally binding cuts amounting to 25 to 40 per cent of their Greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions at the 1990 levels by industrialised countries by 2020

WHAT THE WORLD MAY GET

A non-enforceable pledge to cut down emissions amounting to barely 5 to 17 per cent

► ADAPTATION FUNDING

WHAT THE RICH WERE TO DELIVER

Close to \$400 billion a year in assistance to developing countries for adaptation measures

WHAT THE WORLD MAY GET

Barely \$20 billion a year, half of it through offsets

► CLEAN TECHNOLOGY

WHAT THE RICH WERE TO DELIVER

A mechanism to ensure free flow of the best clean technology to developing countries

WHAT THE WORLD MAY GET

A wishy-washy pledge that has too many riders to be useful; mostly sharing of information

THE COPENHAGEN SUMMIT IS BEING
HELD FROM DECEMBER 7 TO 18

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